



PEOPLE POWER: Modi targeted key sections in the garb of official duties

A HARD-HITTING CAMPAIGN AND THE SUCCESS OF THE GOVERNMENT'S DEVELOPMENTAL WORK TURNED THE TIDE IN FAVOUR OF MODI

ruptible leader capable of taking tough decisions—and the developmental works undertaken by his Government. However, the survey also showed that his sitting MLAs were facing severe anti-incumbency at the local level. Based on this feedback, while distributing tickets, Modi replaced around 38 sitting MLAs, apart from the 11 rebels who had left the party. Where he didn't replace the controversial MLAs, he suffered.

SONIA'S BLUNDER

Sonia Gandhi's ill-advised "merchant of death" remark played right into Modi's hands. It gave him the platform to show his Hindutva face in a more aggressive manner than he had done all through the campaign. Even Modi's spin doctor Arun Jaitley, who is known to advise him against taking an extreme Hindutva plank, agreed that a Hindutva dose was necessary. Sonia's remark was a God-send. From that pivotal moment, Modi launched a high-pitched assault, portraying the

Congress as supporters of terrorists like Azfal Guru and Sohrabuddin. The Congress failed to counter his charge and similar remarks by party general secretary Digvijay Singh and Spokesman Abhishek Singhvi added to the blunder.

Sonia displayed grace and sagacity by not seeking scapegoats and congratulating everybody who had worked hard for the party, but the damage had been done. By failing to project anyone as chief minister, it lost credibility and votes. The biggest mistake it made was that it gave tickets to seven BJP rebels, turning Congress workers against the party.

DEVELOPMENT OR HINDUTVA?

Both issues may have helped him win, but it was the success of his developmental work that turned the tide. Indeed, if the electoral results signify a thumbs-up for his transparent, largely corruption-free style of governance and his unrelenting push

for development, Modi the hate figure could well turn out to be Modi the role model. The visible success of his five-point programme of gyan shakti (knowledge power), oorja shakti (energy power), jal shakti (water power), jan shakti (people power) and raksha shakti (power of security) was too impressive to be ignored.

For Gujaratis, essentially a business-oriented community, such schemes and elimination of bureaucratic red tape proved decisive when it came to deciding whom to vote for. The final word came from a veteran BJP leader: "His critics might accuse him of encouraging a cult around him, but cults can't be cultivated without giving positive results."

That proved the key factor. Every state is not Gujarat and every chief minister may not want to emulate Modi's controversial image or even run an electoral campaign using his kind of rhetoric, but there is certainly a lesson for all of them in the way he has run his Government. ■